

DRIFTHEART

Written by

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Based on A LoreSpinner Original

FADE IN:

EXT. DEEP SPACE - THE SHATTERED WORLD OF ERYTHANE

Black. Then light, wrong light. A planet that no longer exists as one thing.

ERYTHANE. A world split into seven massive fragments, each the size of a continent, tumbling in slow rotation around a molten core that still burns between them. Rivers of magma arc through the vacuum, luminous veins connecting severed limbs.

Chunks of planetary crust, some the size of cities, cartwheel through the void. Dust clouds thick enough to swallow light.

A DROPSHIP appears. Small. Fragile. Threading between continent-sized fragments.

INT. DROPSHIP - CARGO HOLD - CONTINUOUS

Six people in the hold. Salvagers. Freelancers. The kind of people who take jobs that come with a body-count disclaimer.

They sit on fold-down benches bolted to the hull. Weapons stowed. Gear strapped. Faces lit by amber emergency strips and the pale glow of helmet HUDs cycling through pre-drop diagnostics.

KATARIA DARANA (21), sharp-eyed, lean, dark hair pulled back tight. She checks her breathing rig for the third time. Her fingers are steady. Her jaw is not.

Across from her: DRAETH VORN (29), coiled precision in a battered flight jacket. He polishes a sidearm like it's ritual. His eyes track Kataria. Not watching over her. Watching her.

HARSK (40s, heavysset) runs a final check on his shotgun. A child's DRAWING is clipped to his chest harness, stick figures beneath a crayon sun. He catches Kataria looking. Tucks it under the strap without a word.

SENNA (30s, wiry, shaved head) runs her thumb along a catalog of creature GLYPHS tattooed on her forearm. Field names. Kill records. She's the one they bring when nobody knows what they're walking into.

The remaining two are DOSS and KELLAN, younger, greener. Already pale.

The ship SHUDDERS. Hard. Everyone grabs hold.

A DEEP GROAN runs through the hull. Metal flexing. The lights flicker.

KATARIA
How long to the fragment?

DRAETH
(checking a wrist
display)
Four minutes. Maybe less.

He looks at her. Holds the look one beat too long.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
Stay close to me in there.

KATARIA
I can handle myself.

DRAETH
I know you can. That's not why.

He doesn't finish. She lets it go. Out the narrow viewport beside her, the shattered world fills the frame. Continent fragments the color of rust and char, backlit by the exposed core. Beautiful. Terrible.

KATARIA
What are we actually looking for
down there?

DRAETH
What the client paid us to find.

KATARIA
That's not an answer.

DRAETH
It's the one that keeps us all
employed.

She holds his gaze. He doesn't blink. Something unspoken sits between them, and she lets it pass. For now.

PILOT (O.S.)
(over comms, strained)
Thirty seconds to atmosphere. Suit
integrity is mandatory. It's going
to get rough.

Everyone locks helmets. Visors seal with pressurized HISSES.

Draeth reaches across the aisle. Taps Kataria's knee once. She nods.

Then the ship hits the atmosphere.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - UPPER ATMOSPHERE - CONTINUOUS

The dropship punches through a wall of superheated gas. Flames engulf the hull. The ship SCREAMS, metal against friction, turbulence slamming it sideways.

Chunks of orbital debris burn alongside them. Some larger than the ship. A piece of what was once a building tumbles past, trailing fire.

INT. DROPSHIP - CARGO HOLD - CONTINUOUS

VIOLENT SHAKING. Cargo containers strain against their straps. The freelancers grip their harnesses with white knuckles.

DOSS

This is insane, this is.

KELLAN

Shut up and hold on.

A MASSIVE IMPACT.

A SHRIEK of tearing metal that goes through bone. The entire ship lurches sideways. Sparks cascade from ruptured conduits.

Then the hull BREACHES.

A section of the port wall RIPS OPEN, a jagged mouth of twisted metal two meters wide. Atmosphere HOWLS outward. Everything not bolted down rockets toward the gap.

DOSS. His harness buckle, damaged by the impact, SNAPS. He screams. Slides. Claws at the deck plating. His fingers find nothing.

He's PULLED THROUGH THE BREACH. Gone. Swallowed by fire and void.

Kataria lunges for him. Too late. Her hand closes on empty air.

A cargo container breaks free of its straps, two tons of metal swinging. It catches KELLAN across the chest. CRUSHES him against the bulkhead. He doesn't scream. There isn't time.

SENNA

Bulkheads! Seal the bulkheads!

Harsk slams the emergency override. Blast doors DROP, sealing the breach section. The howling stops. Pressure stabilizes. Smoke. Sparking wires. Two dead in under five seconds.

The ship is still falling.

DRAETH

Cockpit. Someone get to the cockpit!

Kataria is already moving. Unclipping her harness. Pulling herself forward through the lurching corridor, hand over hand, gravity shifting as the ship tumbles.

INT. DROPSHIP - CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Kataria fights down the narrow passage. Ceiling panels fall. A conduit bursts, scalding vapor. She ducks, keeps moving.

The cockpit door is buckled. She KICKS it. Again. AGAIN.

It gives.

INT. DROPSHIP - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Both pilots are dead.

Pilot 1 is slumped over the controls. A spear of debris punched through the viewport and through him. Decompression foam has auto-sealed the breach, but it sealed around a corpse.

Pilot 2 is in his chair. Neck at a wrong angle. Console crushed inward against his chest.

Kataria freezes. One second. The longest second of her life.

Alarms. Everywhere. The altimeter is spinning. The ground is coming.

She shoves Pilot 2's body aside. Drops into the blood-slicked seat. Grabs the yoke.

KATARIA

(to herself)

Okay. Okay okay okay.

Through the cracked viewport, the surface of Fragment Seven rushing up. Jagged mountain ranges. Volcanic plains. No runway. No landing zone.

Two options. She can see them both.

OPTION ONE: A narrow canyon that cuts between two mountain ridges. Sheltered, but tight. One wrong correction and they clip a wall and disintegrate.

OPTION TWO: An open volcanic flat. Wide, but the surface ripples with heat distortion. Lava flows beneath a thin crust. They'd land and sink.

She pulls the yoke LEFT. Hard. Into the canyon.

In her side pouch, the containment cylinder HUMS. Faint. The first time it's made a sound since boarding.

KATARIA (CONT'D)
(over comms)
Hold on to something. Now.

The ship banks. Metal GROANS.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - CANYON - CONTINUOUS

The dropship screams through the canyon. Winglets SHEAR OFF against rock walls in showers of sparks. The belly scrapes a ridge, a rooster tail of stone and fire.

INT. DROPSHIP - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Kataria fights the yoke. Every muscle. The ship wants to spin and she will not let it.

She sees it. The canyon opens ahead into a narrow shelf of flat rock. Not much. Enough.

She cuts the engines. Fires retro-thrusters. The ship SLAMS.

Impact. BLACK.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - CRASH SITE - MOMENTS LATER

Silence. Dust settling. The dropship is a ruin, belly-down on the rock shelf, hull cracked open. One engine still burns. Smoke pours from every seam.

A long beat. Nothing moves.

Then the emergency hatch BLOWS outward.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - CRASH SITE - CONTINUOUS

KATARIA climbs out first. Helmet sealed. Breathing hard. She turns back and helps DRAETH through. Then HARSK. Then SENNA. Four. Out of eight.

They stand in the wreckage. The air beyond their helmets is a haze of sulfur-yellow particulate.

The ground beneath their boots is cracked basalt, veined with dull orange, heat from below. Every few seconds, a deep THRUM vibrates through the rock.

Kataria looks up.

THE SKY.

The other fragments of Erythane hang overhead. Close enough to see mountain ranges on their surfaces.

They rotate slowly, casting continent-sized shadows that sweep across the terrain. Between them, the exposed planetary core pulses, a bruised sun of molten iron and dying light.

She stares too long. Draeth's hand on her shoulder breaks it.

DRAETH

The cathedral. One point two klicks northwest. Built into the base of that ridge.

He points. Through the haze, barely visible, a MOUNTAIN. And at its base, carved into the living rock: the faint outline of massive architectural forms. Spires. Arches. The CATHEDRAL.

Kataria notices Draeth's wrist display. The nav-data on his screen doesn't match the job briefing they all downloaded. Different coordinates. A deeper waypoint. He angles it away before she can read the rest.

She clocks it. Doesn't say anything.

KATARIA

Then we move.

DRAETH

Stay tight. Stay armed. This planet's been dead for a thousand years but the readings on the descent were.

He trails off. Looks at the cracked ground beneath them. Something flickers in the fissures. A dull, ember-orange glow. Moving.

DRAETH (CONT'D)

Wrong.

KATARIA

Wrong how?

DRAETH

Thermal signatures. Organic. Moving in patterns.

SENNA

(checking her forearm
glyphs, then the
fissures)

Nothing in the catalogs moves like that.

Beat.

KATARIA

Let's move. Fast.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - VOLCANIC PLAINS - CONTINUOUS

The four freelancers move across the blasted terrain in a loose formation. Draeth on point. Kataria beside him. Harsk and Senna covering the rear.

The landscape is hell.

Fissures split the ground every few meters, some narrow enough to step over, some wide enough to swallow a person.

Volcanic vents hiss jets of superheated gas. The rock itself is unstable, plates of basalt shifting and grinding.

Kataria falls into step with Draeth. Keeps her voice low.

KATARIA

You've been here before.

DRAETH

What makes you say that?

KATARIA

You haven't looked at the map once since we started walking.

He doesn't answer. Just adjusts his grip on his weapon and picks up the pace. She watches his back.

A hundred meters out. Two hundred. Three.

Harsk stops.

HARSK

Hold.

Everyone freezes.

HARSK (CONT'D)

You feel that?

The ground is vibrating. Not the deep planetary thrum from before. Something else. Localized. Getting stronger.

SENNA

Under us. Something's under us.

A CRACK splits the rock three meters to their left. Not a fissure. Something FORCING its way through from below. The basalt buckles upward, then SHATTERS.

A mass of fluid black pulls itself from the earth. Veins of burning orange and red crack across its surface. It radiates heat, visible heat distortion warping the air around it.

The shape is almost humanoid. Almost. It shifts and reforms constantly, limbs extending and retracting, a body that can't decide what it is. It has no face. But it orients toward them. It knows they're there.

Then another crack. Behind them. Another to the right. FOUR MORE pulling themselves free. Surrounding them.

Senna's eyes go wide. Her thumb traces the blank space at the end of her forearm catalog. Room for one more.

SENNA (CONT'D)

(backing up, weapon
raised)

Cinders.

She fires. Her pulse rifle hits the nearest creature center-mass. The round PUNCHES through. Black fluid sprays, instantly igniting into orange flame where it hits air. The creature staggers. Reforms. Keeps coming.

DRAETH

The bright spots. Hit the ember
lines!

Draeth fires. Precise. Two shots into the glowing fissures that crack across the creature's torso.

It SHRIEKS, a sound of superheated metal quenched in water, and collapses into a pool of hissing black.

But there are more. Always more. Cracks opening everywhere now. The ground itself is birthing them.

KATARIA

Run! Cathedral! Now!

They run. Firing behind them. The Cinders pursue. Not fast, but relentless. They flow over terrain, THROUGH fissures, reforming on the other side. One reaches for Senna.

Its hand closes on her arm. Where it touches, her suit MELTS. She screams. Draeth spins, fires point-blank into the creature's head. It drops. Senna stumbles forward, arm scorched but moving.

DRAETH

Keep going.

They run harder. The cathedral growing larger ahead. Close now.

A fissure ERUPTS directly in their path. Three Cinders rise from it simultaneously. Harsk doesn't slow down. He barrels into them, fires his shotgun into the first, drives his armored shoulder into the second.

HARSK

Get to the door! I'll hold them!

KATARIA

Harsk.

HARSK

I got kids who need me to buy you thirty seconds, Darana. Don't waste them.

He fires again. And again. A Cinder latches onto his back. Another onto his leg. He ROARS. Keeps firing. Buying them seconds.

Kataria, Draeth, and Senna sprint the last hundred meters.

Behind them, Harsk goes down. The Cinders swarm him. His weapon discharges twice more, then stops. The ember-glow intensifies where he fell.

He doesn't get back up.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - CATHEDRAL ENTRANCE - CONTINUOUS

The cathedral doors. Massive. Thirty meters tall. Carved from the mountain itself, black stone etched with patterns that seem to move in peripheral vision. VEIL GLYPHS.

Ancient. Geometric. Spiraling inward toward a central locking mechanism.

No handle. No obvious entry point. Just the glyphs and the mountain.

Behind them, the Cinders. Dozens now. Flowing across the terrain. Two hundred meters and closing.

SENNA

(scanning the creatures,
then the door)

They're massing at the fissure
line. Sixty seconds before the
first wave hits us.

KATARIA

Working on it.

She studies the locking mechanism. A series of concentric rings carved into the stone, each bearing different glyph sequences. They're meant to be aligned.

DRAETH

The rings rotate. You need to match
the harmonic sequence.

KATARIA

How do you know that?

DRAETH

Job briefing.

KATARIA

Our job briefing said "recover
salvage from a ruin." Not one word
about Veil ciphers.

He doesn't answer. The Cinders are screaming behind them. No time to press it.

KATARIA (CONT'D)

Which harmonic sequence? There are
six rings and at least forty
glyphs.

She stops. Looks closer. The innermost ring has a pattern she recognizes. Not from a database. Not from a briefing.

From somewhere older. The margins of old star charts she studied as a girl. Shapes she traced with her finger on a balcony overlooking the void, half a lifetime ago.

Her hand moves before her brain catches up. She rotates the inner ring. CLICK. The glyphs pulse with faint blue light.

SENNA
(weapon up, eyes on the
plain)
Forty seconds.

Second ring. She reads the pattern, finds the complement. Rotates. CLICK.

Third ring. Fourth. Faster now. Her hands moving with a certainty that frightens her.

Fifth ring. CLICK.

Sixth ring. She hesitates.

Two possible alignments. The first is mathematical. Clean. The glyphs line up by symmetry. It's the answer anyone with enough time could solve.

The second makes no logical sense. The glyphs don't match. But something in her BODY knows it. The same way she knew the canyon was right.

SENNA (CONT'D)
Kataria. Twenty seconds.

She can hear them. The metal-quench shriek. Dozens of voices.

She chooses the one her hands choose. The one that costs her the certainty of logic.

CLICK.

Deep inside the mountain, past corridors they haven't reached yet, the shard on its pedestal FLARES. A pulse of blue-white that travels through stone. Through the floor. Through Kataria's boots.

She feels it. Doesn't understand it. Not yet.

The doors GROAN. Stone grinding against stone. Ancient mechanisms firing for the first time in millennia. The thirty-meter doors begin to swing inward.

DRAETH
Go. Go. Go.

They squeeze through the widening gap. Senna last, turning to fire a final burst at the nearest Cinder. Twenty meters away. Reaching.

The doors SLAM SHUT. The sound echoes through stone.

Silence.

INT. CATHEDRAL OF THE VEIL - ENTRANCE HALL - CONTINUOUS

Darkness. Then light. Soft. Blue-white. Coming from the walls themselves.

VEIL GLYPHS. Thousands of them. Carved into every surface. Floor, walls, the vaulted ceiling fifty meters above. They pulse. Slow rhythms.

Stone arches buttressed by something that isn't stone. Pillars carved with spiraling glyph-work that extends beyond sight. The floor is polished obsidian, mirror-smooth. Part cathedral. Part alien machine.

Senna catches her breath. Draeth checks his weapon. Kataria does neither.

She stares at the glyphs. She's shaking. Not from fear.

KATARIA

I've seen these before.

DRAETH

(too quickly)

The Veil Glyphs are documented in salvage databases. You've probably.

KATARIA

No. Not in a database. I've, seen them.

He doesn't respond. His hand, the one still gripping his weapon, relaxes. A man who just got the answer to a question he's been carrying for a long time.

KATARIA (CONT'D)

You knew I'd recognize them.

DRAETH

The artifact is in the central chamber. Let's move.

KATARIA

That's the third time you've dodged a question, Draeth.

DRAETH

And that sound you hear is the
clock running out on all of us.
Move.

She holds his gaze. Two seconds. Three. Then she moves. But the way she positions herself as they walk, she keeps him in her peripheral vision. Not behind her. Never behind her again.

INT. CATHEDRAL OF THE VEIL - CENTRAL CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

They enter the heart of the cathedral.

The chamber is vast. Circular. The ceiling opens into a natural shaft in the mountain, and through it, the dying core of Erythane burns far above.

Its light falls in a single column onto the chamber floor.

And there, at the center, floating above a pedestal of raw obsidian: THE DRIFTHEART SHARD.

The size of a fist. Crystalline. Its interior swirls with light that has no source. It rotates slowly. It hums, a low, resonant frequency that vibrates in the chest, not the ears.

Ancient. Alive.

The Veil Glyphs across every surface of the chamber pulse in synchronization with the shard's rotation. The whole room breathes with it.

SENNA

That's what we came for?

DRAETH

Don't touch anything. Not yet.

Kataria takes a step forward. The glyphs on the floor beneath her boot FLARE, brighter than the others. A ripple of light cascades outward from where she stands, racing across the floor, up the walls, across the ceiling.

Everyone freezes.

She takes another step. Another flare. The glyphs are responding to HER. Draeth and Senna stand on the same floor and nothing happens. But where Kataria walks, the cathedral wakes up.

The hum from the shard INTENSIFIES. Changes pitch. A note of recognition.

Draeth exhales. Slow. Controlled. He lowers his weapon. Closes his eyes for one beat. A man whose long bet just paid off.

DRAETH (CONT'D)

(soft)

Go to it, Kata. It's waiting for you.

KATARIA

You don't seem surprised.

DRAETH

Please. Just trust me. One more time.

The weight of those words. She hears it. She files it.

Kataria crosses the chamber. Each step ignites more glyphs. By the time she reaches the pedestal, the entire room is blazing, every symbol lit, every surface alive with cascading light.

She reaches out.

Her fingers close around the DRIFTHEART SHARD.

And the world BREAKS.

A SHOCKWAVE detonates from the pedestal. A ring of visible force SLAMS outward in every direction. Kataria is thrown backward, the shard clutched to her chest.

The glyphs go from blue-white to BLINDING. The hum becomes a ROAR. The cathedral SHAKES. The building itself is reacting. Defending. ATTACKING.

Columns of energy ERUPT from the glyph-work. Random. Devastating.

Senna spins toward Kataria, moving to cover her. One boot still planted on the obsidian. She reaches out.

A column of Veilfire tears through the floor between them.

It rips through Senna. UNMADE. Disintegrated in a flash of blue-white.

KATARIA

No!

The chamber is collapsing. The ceiling shaft cracking. Massive blocks of ancient stone falling. Energy arcing between the walls.

Draeth. Running toward Kataria. A column CRACKS. A section of ceiling the size of a vehicle drops. He dives, but not fast enough.

The debris catches his left leg. CRUSHES it. He goes down hard. Face-first against the obsidian floor.

KATARIA (CONT'D)

Draeth!

She scrambles to him. Pulls at the debris. It doesn't move. His leg is pinned, shattered under tons of ancient stone.

He grabs her arm. Pulls her close. His face through the visor: pain, but also something else. Relief. The worst kind.

DRAETH

(through gritted teeth)

Kata. Listen to me.

KATARIA

I'm getting you out.

DRAETH

Listen.

She stops.

DRAETH (CONT'D)

I sent a signal. Before we landed.
Ashen trace, through the Veil. I
thought they'd intercept. Shadow
us. I didn't think they'd.

He looks at the collapsing chamber. At where Senna stood.

DRAETH (CONT'D)

I didn't know it would do this.

KATARIA

What?

DRAETH

The Ashen Armada. They've been
looking for the shard. I told them
where to find it. Thought I could
play both sides. Thought I could
control it.

Beat. The words land.

KATARIA

You put me on this crew.

DRAETH

Yes.

KATARIA

You chose me. Because you knew I
could open it.

DRAETH

I suspected. I wasn't certain
until.

KATARIA

(quiet, worse than
yelling)
Harsk had kids.

Draeth flinches. No defense for that. Nothing to say.

KATARIA (CONT'D)

Senna was standing right next to
me.

DRAETH

I know.

Silence. Just the cathedral dying around them. Stone falling.
Energy cascading.

He reaches up. Takes her hand. She almost pulls away.

Almost.

His thumb traces a small circle on her wrist. The same absent
gesture he made in the cargo hold. The knee tap. The look
held too long. All the same language. All real, and all part
of the con, and she can't separate them and that's the worst
part.

A CRACK. The floor between them splits. Energy surges upward
through the gap. Blue-white, then darker. Veins of something
wrong in the light. Something black. Metallic.

DRAETH (CONT'D)

Take the shard. Get to the ship.
The Veil-sled in the aft bay should
still be functional.

KATARIA

I'm not leaving you.

She pulls at the debris. Stone tears her gloves. Blood on the
obsidian. It doesn't move.

The shard clutched to her chest BURNS. Not pain. Recognition. A frequency that says: this is what you are. Someone who holds on.

DRAETH

You are. And you will. Because if you don't, everything that just happened was for nothing.

He squeezes her hand. The rift behind him WIDENS. The dark energy pulses. In its depth, something MOVES. A tendril. Dark metallic. Reaching.

DRAETH (CONT'D)

Forgive me, Kata.

The rift SWALLOWS him. A flash of dark light, contradictory, impossible. The debris, the stone, Draeth, all pulled into the fracture. In the last instant before it seals: the dark metallic tendril, coiling around something, someone, and pulling it deeper.

Then the rift closes. The floor seals.

Draeth is gone.

Kataria stands alone in the dying cathedral. The Driftheart Shard pulses in her hand, its light synced to her heartbeat.

She screams. No words. Just sound.

Then she runs.

INT. CATHEDRAL OF THE VEIL - CORRIDORS - CONTINUOUS

Kataria sprints through the collapsing cathedral. The shard clutched in one hand. Weapon in the other.

The building is tearing itself apart. Walls cracking. Ceilings caving. Veil Glyphs exploding in bursts of energy as their millennia-old systems overload.

She vaults a fallen column. Ducks under a collapsing arch. A blast of Veilfire erupts from the wall. She drops, slides under it, keeps moving.

The entrance hall. The massive doors, still sealed. But the stone around them is fracturing. She spots a gap where the wall has split. Narrow. Sharp-edged. Barely passable.

She doesn't hesitate. She turns sideways and FORCES herself through. Stone tears at her suit. She bleeds. She doesn't stop.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - CATHEDRAL ENTRANCE - CONTINUOUS

She bursts out into the toxic air. Helmet sealed. Lungs burning anyway.

Behind her, the cathedral is IMPLODING. The mountain itself is cracking, the ancient structure folding inward.

And the Cinders. Everywhere.

The ground for a hundred meters in every direction is crawling with them. Black-oil bodies streaked with ember-light, rising from every fissure, drawn to the energy release.

Kataria doesn't slow down.

She fires as she runs. The shard pulses in her grip and, something new, where its light touches the nearest Cinder, the creature RECOILS. Hissing. Imperfect, temporary, but enough to create a gap.

She runs through it.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - VOLCANIC PLAINS - CONTINUOUS

The terrain that took them twenty minutes to cross, she covers in five. Sprinting. Leaping fissures. The ground BUCKLING beneath her as the cathedral's collapse sends shockwaves through the fragment's unstable geology.

Behind her: the mountain is coming apart. The cathedral's destruction cascading, triggering fault lines, rupturing magma chambers. The fragment is dying. Again.

Ahead: the crashed dropship. Broken. Smoking. But there.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - CRASH SITE - CONTINUOUS

Kataria reaches the wreckage. The main hull is crushed. Unsalvageable. But the aft bay is still in tact.

She tears open the emergency access panel. Inside: the VEIL-SLED. A compact emergency escape craft, barely larger than a coffin with an engine. Designed for one occupant, one jump. Dented, scorched from the crash, but the status lights blink GREEN.

The ground HEAVES. A fissure opens ten meters away. Cinders pour from it. The volcanic plain behind her is splitting, magma visible now, rising.

She rips the Veil-sled free of its moorings. Drags it clear of the wreckage. Pops the canopy.

Climbs in. Slams the canopy shut. Powers up.

The Veil-sled's engine WHINES, building charge. The craft vibrates. Not ready yet. Not ready yet.

A Cinder slams against the canopy. Black fluid and ember-light pressed against the glass, centimeters from her face. The heat cracks the outer layer.

KATARIA
(to the sled)
Come on. Come on.

Another Cinder. Three more. They pile onto the sled, their heat warping the hull plating.

The engine hits critical charge.

She fires.

EXT. FRAGMENT SEVEN - SKY - CONTINUOUS

The Veil-sled LAUNCHES. A streak of blue-white cutting straight up through the toxic atmosphere. Cinders fall away, burning off in the friction of acceleration.

Below: Fragment Seven RUPTURES. The cathedral's mountain splits in half. Magma erupts in columns. The crust folds inward. A piece of a world that was already dead, dying again.

The sled clears the atmosphere. Behind it, Fragment Seven cracks apart in absolute silence. No sound in space. Just light. A silent eruption of orange and white that blooms outward, illuminating the other six fragments. A second, momentary sun.

Then darkness. Debris. Silence.

INT. VEIL-SLED - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Kataria. Alone.

The cockpit is tiny. Emergency lighting. The hum of a minimal life support system. Through the narrow viewport, the expanding debris cloud where Fragment Seven used to be.

The DRIFTHEART SHARD rests in her lap. It hums. Low. Constant. Its light pulses in rhythm with her heartbeat.

She stares at it. Her reflection in its surface.

She reaches to her wrist. A thin silver chain. A CHARM, small, tarnished, engraved with a symbol too small to read.

A piece of a life before this one.

She unclasps it. Holds it in her palm. Closes her fingers around it one last time.

Katarina reaches forward. Opens the manual vent. A small pressure hatch the size of a fist, designed for jettisoning waste.

She opens her hand. The charm tumbles into the void. A speck of silver swallowed by the black. The vent seals.

Silence. The sled drifts. No heading. No destination. Just momentum and debris.

Her hand finds the shard. Holds it against her chest. Its pulse matches hers. She can feel it learning her rhythm.

KATARIA (V.O.)

Draeth used to say the void humbles you. Makes you small. He was wrong about that too.

She stares through the viewport. Fragment Seven is gone.

Just a wound in space where rock used to be.

KATARIA (V.O.)

It doesn't make you small. It just shows you what's left when everything burns off. And right now that's me, a stolen shard, and a direction I can't explain.

Her thumb traces the shard's edge. The same absent gesture Draeth made on her wrist. She catches herself doing it. Stops.

KATARIA (V.O.)

Four people are dead because a man I trusted made a phone call.

(MORE)

KATARIA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 And the thing that killed them
 wants me to hold it. Hums for me.
 Knows my heartbeat already.

The shard's light shifts. Warmer. She looks down at it.

KATARIA (V.O.)
 I should throw it out the same
 vent.

A long beat. She doesn't.

She straps in. Hands on the Veil-drive controls. Through the viewport, nothing but stars and the graveyard of a shattered world.

KATARIA (V.O.)
 I didn't.

She SLAMS the Veil-drive.

The sled LEAPS forward, reality bending around it, light stretching, the stars smearing into infinite lines, and then the craft is SWALLOWED by the Veil. Gone.

Empty space. Drifting debris. The ghost-light of a dead planet.

SMASH TO BLACK.

SILENCE.

Then, a low hum. Building. The shard's frequency. Growing until it fills the darkness.

TITLE CARD: DRIFTHEART

The hum fades. Black holds.

Then:

FIVE YEARS LATER.

EXT. MERIDIAN STATION - THE SINTER - NIGHT

The SINTER: a vertigo stack of industrial chasms, scaffolded sky-bridges, and neon-soaked exhaust clouds. Gravity stabilizers GROAN beneath the megastructure.

Mag-rails scream overhead, hauling ore barges. Drone traffic zigzags through heat shimmer and coolant vapor.

A STOLEN HOVERBIKE BLURS into view, slicing between freight lanes.

KATARIA, now twenty-six, leaner than we last saw her, visor cracked, hazard light glinting in her eyes. Every move is survival, sharpened over five years of running.

She banks hard, kicking off a vertical column. PLASMA JETS bloom blue.

FLASH MEMORY:

The cathedral floor splitting. Draeth's hand in hers. The rift swallowing him whole.

BACK TO SCENE:

Her jaw tightens. She accelerates, fingers brushing the side pouch.

A faint HUM beneath the roar: the DRIFTHEART SHARD, sealed in its containment cylinder.

TWO CORPORATE SECURITY DRONES dive after her, sirens wailing.

KATARIA

(into comm)

Clo, if you're listening, now's a great time to clear me a runway.

HUD: The bike's display flashes red.

ILLEGAL VESSEL // FORCE TERMINATION IN PROGRESS

She slams a spike device into the console.

CLOAK GRID ENGAGED.

The bike FLICKERS, distortion bending her signal trail. The drones scramble.

INT. SINTER VENTILATOR SHAFT - CONTINUOUS

Steam blinds. Fan blades spin. Guillotines.

Kataria dives through, inches from metal teeth.

One drone clips a rotor, SHREDDING into a firestorm of sparks.

EXT. MAINTENANCE CATWALK - CONTINUOUS

She BURSTS onto a suspended walkway above a molten alloy pit. The second drone CLOSE BEHIND.

She whips the bike around and LAUNCHES OFF THE EDGE.

EXT. ORE TRAM - CONTINUOUS

The hoverbike arcs high toward a tram far below.

CLO waits across the tramway, framed in flickering industrial light, EMP GRENADE in hand.

KATARIA
(into comm)
Clo, lock and load!

She FLIPS the bike midair, thrusters SCREAMING.

CLO
Coming in hot!

SLOW MOTION:

The EMP spins. Sparks.

Kataria SNATCHES it mid-flight, powers down the bike.

The bike drops away, free-falling.

She leaps, ACTIVATING the EMP.

The drone convulses, powers down, CRASHES into the platform.

END SLOW MOTION:

Kataria SLAMS down on the tram, rolls, skids toward the molten edge.

Her hand SNAGS a steel bar. Inches from liquid fire.

She hauls herself up, hair singed at the tips. Clo just stares.

KATARIA
Told you I'd bring back parts.

CLO
That was parts?

She flicks a disrupt spike into the downed drone. It flares.
Its whole profile vanishes from scanners.

CLO (CONT'D)
You just wiped its signature?

KATARIA
Why waste a good stealth core?

VEERA (V.O.)
Of course you stole it. And I
already hate it. Cargo bay. Now.

KATARIA
Sweep it for trackers.

VEERA (V.O.)
Already done. I also found three
additional vulnerabilities you
missed. You're welcome.

They stride into the steam. Clo is quiet for a beat. Then:

CLO
Sometimes I wonder if I was the
first.

KATARIA
First what?

CLO
Clone. Version. Whatever. Maybe
there's another one out there.
Still waiting to be pulled out of
the dark.

Kataria doesn't answer. Her hand brushes the shard pouch. It
HUMS.

She looks ahead. Eyes hard.

CUT TO:

EXT. HAWKMOON GARAGE - LOWER SINTER - NIGHT

A rusted docking bay carved between vent shafts. Neon letters
flicker: HAWKMOON REPAIRS. Coolant lines HUM overhead.

INT. GARAGE FLOOR - CONTINUOUS

Kataria SLAMS the scorched hoverbike part onto a slab. It still smolders.

Clo heaves the broken drone carcass onto a lift table.

CLO

We still owe on two reactor cycles.
And we're out of ration chits.

VEERA (V.O.)

Correction. You owe. I'm an unpaid
hostage.

KATARIA

You're a ship core with sarcasm
protocols. We're lucky you're not
charging us rent.

VEERA (V.O.)

I considered it. Then remembered
your credit rating.

A terminal flickers. A distorted FAR WATCH SIGIL pulses weakly.

Kataria's hand stops on the drone carcass. She turns.

KATARIA

Ghost-signal. Far Watch code
fragment.

VEERA (V.O.)

From a derelict kiosk near the rim.
Tier-3 data burst. Encrypted.

CLO

Could be bait.

KATARIA

Could be the first real lead in two
years.

VEERA's console CHIRPS again. Harsher.

VEERA (V.O.)

New transmission. Marked priority.
The Iron Ledger.

Kataria freezes.

CLO

That's bad, right?

Kataria crosses the floor. Slams her hand on the console. A grim icon flickers: IRON LEDGER COLLECTION NOTICE.

VEERA (V.O.)

Three days until enforcement
protocol. Maybe less. They moved
the deadline.

CLO

What kind of enforcement?

KATARIA

The kind where they take the ship
apart while we're still inside it.

OUTSIDE THE PULLDOWN: A BLACKED-OUT LEDGER OPERATIVE watches from the shadows. Ocular implants flicker faint red. A slow click of gauntlet fingers. Then he melts back into the mist.

INT. GARAGE FLOOR - LATER

The chaos has cooled. Dim lights. Old conduits HUM in the walls.

Kataria sits alone at the cluttered workbench. A mug of synthcaf steams beside her. The DRIFTHEART SHARD rests on the table, faintly pulsing. Between her fingers, she turns Draeth's scorched insignia. Feeling, not looking.

Clo enters quietly. Sits without asking.

CLO

Still spinning that thing like
it'll give you answers?

KATARIA

If I spin it fast enough, maybe
it'll rewind far enough to matter.

A beat. Familiar silence between them.

CLO

We're not just out of creds, Kat.
We're out of road.

KATARIA

Road's a luxury for people not
being hunted.

CLO

You think it's the shard that's
drawing them?

She glances at it. The shard pulses, as if it heard.

KATARIA

Older than the Accord. Older than the Veil. Nobody built this. It was here first.

CLO

You said there were others.

KATARIA

Vault fragments spoke of three. One to map. One to breach. One to command.

CLO

And worth killing for.

KATARIA

Which is why someone already tried.

She tosses down the insignia. It clatters against the workbench.

KATARIA (CONT'D)

Draeth knew. He gave up our location five years ago to get inside that first Vault. Set the whole crew up. Set me up.

CLO

You think he knew what you were?

KATARIA

Not at first. But when it opened for me and the others didn't walk out, he started watching me like I was the lock.

A heavy beat.

CLO

So where is he now?

KATARIA

Gone. Dead, maybe.

VEERA (V.O.)

No verified activity on stellarnet, bounty logs, or necrotic veil tags. Probability of survival: statistically null.

CLO

Good. One less ghost to chase.

VEERA (V.O.)

Unconfirmed absence is not absence.
Merely untracked presence.

Kataria picks up the insignia. Studies the scorch pattern.
Then pockets it.

KATARIA

If that kiosk has navdata, a dead
pilot's log, even a veil echo, it
might show us where the shard wants
to go next.

CLO

You sure we're ready?

KATARIA

No. But if we sit here, the Ledger
takes the ship in three days. And
if someone else finds the second
Vault before we do, they won't need
me alive to open it.

That lands. Clo processes it.

CLO

So it's run toward the thing that
might kill us, or wait for the
thing that definitely will.

KATARIA

You're learning.

VEERA (V.O.)

Shall I prep sealed gear protocols?

KATARIA

Do it.

Clo grabs his gear. Pauses at the door.

CLO

If this doesn't work...

KATARIA

Then at least we chose how it
ended.

The shard pulses. Stronger this time.

She tucks it deep into her jacket.

EXT. LOWER SINTER - TRANSIT CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Kataria and Clo move fast and quiet through the underbelly of the Sinter. The walls sweat condensation, pulsing faintly with power leaks. Cracked light-panels flicker overhead. Somewhere deep in the pipes, water hammers against rust.

They round a corner to a tunnel wall layered in graffiti:

"HOPE IS A SYSTEM GLITCH."

"BREATHE FREE OR NOT AT ALL."

A half-scrubbed FAR WATCH EMBLEM beneath it all.

CLO

Thought the Watch cleaned this stretch.

KATARIA

They stopped when patrols started vanishing.

They descend a narrow metal stairwell. Broken steps.

Dripping echoes.

A LOW MECHANICAL CHITTERING.

They freeze. Clo's hand goes to his weapon.

The shadows shift. Scavenger mechs, fighting over a dead power cell. Nothing more.

They keep moving.

EXT. SINTER MARKET WASTE CHANNEL - MOMENTS LATER

The route narrows between warped steel supports. Steam seeps from fractured pipes.

They pass a makeshift shanty hidden in a collapsed cargo duct. A child watches from behind a tattered sheet. Eyes wide. Shining in the dark.

Kataria stops. Reaches into her jacket, pulls a worn ration bar, and drops it on the floor.

The child vanishes with the food.

CLO

There's no contract here, Kat.
She's not a job.

KATARIA

Not trying to. Just the ones I see.

They move on. Ahead, a FAINT BLUE PULSE cuts through the haze. Throbbing in the fog beyond.

KATARIA (CONT'D)

There.

CLO

That's the kiosk?

KATARIA

That's the first honest signal
we've had in months.

The pulse quickens. Clo's HUD glitches for half a second, static crawling his display.

They push forward into steam and shadow.

EXT. THE SINTER - ABANDONED CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Steam coils around Clo and Kataria as they move fast but quiet. The walls hum faintly with old, half-dead energy.

Ahead, a derelict FAR WATCH KIOSK. Rusted. Flickering. Its cracked display barely holding on.

Above it, half-lit: LOOK FAR. MAP TRUE. COME HOME.

Kataria slows.

KATARIA

It's still broadcasting.

CLO

There hasn't been a clean Watch
signal in years.

The DRIFTHEART SHARD, hidden beneath her coat, PULSES faintly. Steam shivers in sync. The kiosk flickers harder.

VEERA (V.O.)

Unstable link. Residual veil echo
in the signal. Possible live spike.

Kataria steps forward. Fingers dance over the cracked console. A burst of corrupted static resolves into distorted coordinates overlaying a sector of uncharted Veil.

A single word bleeds onto the display in broken script.
ECHORIFT.

CLO
Never heard of it.

KATARIA
That's because it doesn't want to
be found.

The console spasms. For a heartbeat, an ASHEN GLYPH burns across the screen, glitching into her vision. The same geometric spirals from the cathedral door. Five years and a dead planet away, and they found her here.

Kataria freezes. Breath tightens.

CLO
What was that?

KATARIA
Something that shouldn't exist on a
station kiosk.

She pulls the data. The console spits out a small DATA SPIKE and a crystalline MAP NODE. She pockets both.

KATARIA (CONT'D)
These coordinates. They're off-
Seam. Way off. No registered lane,
no Stitch Point, no beacon.

CLO
So either someone charted a path
nobody else knows about...

KATARIA
Or nobody who took it came back to
file it.

She studies the map node. Turns it in her fingers. The shard in her jacket pulses in time with the node's faint glow.

Same frequency. Same source.

KATARIA (CONT'D)
It's connected. Same signature as
the shard.

CLO
Which means whoever sent this
signal knew what you're carrying.

That sits between them. Heavy.

Kataria holds the map node closer to the shard. Both pulse faster. Syncing.

CLO (CONT'D)
What are you doing?

KATARIA
Listening.

She closes her eyes. The shard's hum deepens. The map node vibrates between her fingers. Steam in the corridor bends toward her, drawn by a gravity that isn't there.

FLASH:

The cathedral floor. Veil glyphs spiraling. The sixth ring turning under her palm. Her body knowing what her brain couldn't.

BACK TO SCENE:

Her eyes snap open. She rotates the map node ninety degrees. It CLICKS into a configuration the data spike alone couldn't have revealed. New coordinates layer over the old ones. Deeper. More precise. A route through Veil-space that no nav-computer would calculate.

VEERA (V.O.)
That trajectory doesn't exist in
any database.

KATARIA
It exists in this.

She presses the shard to the node. A pulse of light. The two objects resonate, a harmonic that vibrates through the corridor walls.

For one instant, the kiosk display flares. Not coordinates this time. An IMAGE. A structure. Massive. Crystalline. Floating in darkness.

Then it's gone.

CLO
What was that?

KATARIA
Where we're going.

She tucks both objects deep in her jacket. The shard settles against her ribs. Warm. Closer than before.

KATARIA (CONT'D)
Load the Strix. We ride the Seam at
zero-six.

CLO

I thought we were laying low.

KATARIA

We are. Nobody sane takes this route.

BEHIND THEM: A LENS irises open in the wall. Then another.

Different angle. Both recording.

The shard pulses once more. Deeper this time.

CUT TO:

EXT. ORBITAL ANGLE - MERIDIAN STATION - CONTINUOUS

The faint signal from the kiosk ripples into the void. A drifting pulse of blue light.

It travels, past cargo haulers and patrol skiffs, until it touches a shape in the black.

A sleek AXIOM CORP CORVETTE, holding in geosync above the station. Its void-black plating absorbs starlight.

Swallowing reflections whole.

INT. CORVETTE - SECURED INNER CHAMBER - DEEP VOID

No lights. Only BLOOD-RED pulses from embedded ASHEN RUNES. The air bends inward. Pressure builds.

The architecture defies geometry. Walls curve without edges. Angles that shouldn't exist, holding together by dark Veil energy.

DRAETH enters. Older. Hardened. The scorch marks on his neck have spread, black veins crawling up his jaw.

Living runes. Feeding.

At the center, an ASHEN ENFORCER hangs in suspended animation. Undead. Hooded in ashsteel threads. Bone

splinters pierce cracked armor. In its chest, a glowing singularity of anti-life, pulsing.

DRAETH

She took the bait.

The Enforcer does not move. But invisible pressure ripples the air. Draeth's breath clouds despite no cold.

FLASH:

His family. Wife, daughter. Trapped in STASIS PODS.

Suspended in psychic scream-fields. Blood tears drift. Their mouths stretch wide, endlessly. No sound escapes.

BACK:

ENFORCER (V.O. / PSIONIC)
She opens the Vault. Or we open
them.

Draeth's hand trembles. He steadies it against his thigh.

DRAETH
She'll go. She has to.

ENFORCER (V.O. / PSIONIC)
Faith. Fragile.

The Enforcer's jaw CRACKS open. Not to speak. To exhale a slow coil of black SMOKE. It writhes upward.

ENFORCER (CONT'D)
Suffering is eternal.

The pressure snaps. Draeth staggers back, spine arched in psychic recoil.

INT. CORVETTE - BRIDGE - MOMENTS LATER

Draeth steadies himself. Blood and sweat streaking his face. He approaches a HOLO-RELAY ALTAR. Ancient Far Watch tech, corrupted with abyssal code.

He keys the transmission. Coordinates flicker onscreen, matching the burn pattern sealed in Kataria's data spike.

The route he built for her. The path he knew she'd take because he knows her.

DRAETH
Only one pilot reckless enough to
fly it.

A soft ping. Confirmation. INCOMING ACCEPTANCE CONFIRMATION:
KATARIA

He stares at her name on the screen. His thumb hovers over the glass where the letters glow.

Then he reaches for a control.

ACTIVATE: HUNTER MINE SWARM

EXT. CORVETTE - HULL - CONTINUOUS

A vent IRISES OPEN. Inside, sleek hunter mines unfold. Their sensor arrays flare. Catching a scent.

They launch. Silent. Fast. Vanishing into the Veil.

CUT TO:

EXT. LOWER SINTER - EDGE OF THE ZONE - NIGHT

Kataria walks ahead of Clo toward the docking slips. Her steps are sharp, focused.

The DRIFTHEART SHARD pulses in her jacket.

Her breath falters. One hand to the wall.

FLASH:

The cathedral floor splitting open. Veilfire erupting. Three shards, spinning apart in darkness.

FLASH CUT:

Kataria steadies herself. Pushes off the wall. Keeps walking.

CLO (O.S.)

Kat?

KATARIA

I'm fine. Ship. Now.

Behind her in the steam, a VEIL-SHADOW ripples. Then is gone.

CUT TO:

INT. THE STRIX - ENGINE CORE - LATER

Hissing steam. Tool clatter. Sparks spit as Kataria hangs upside-down in the Veil Drive housing, sleeves rolled, face smudged. Wires and memory wafers exposed.

VEERA (V.O.)
Twenty-one percent of jury-rigged
Veil jumps end in catastrophic
disintegration.

KATARIA
You're running on hacked firmware,
Veera. Don't get righteous.

VEERA (V.O.)
I'm not righteous. I'm immortal.

CLO (O.S.)
This cable's scorched.

Clo holds up a frayed junction coupler.

KATARIA
It still conducts. We only need
thirty seconds past death.

CLO
Thirty seconds past death. That's
the most optimistic thing you've
said all week.

KATARIA
Hand me the phase stabilizer.

CLO
Broken one or brokener one?

KATARIA
Surprise me.

CUT TO:

INT. THE STRIX - COCKPIT - LATER

A patched-together fusion of Accord-era tech and outlaw
salvage. Panels glow unevenly. Exposed wires pulse faint
Veillight. The canopy is heat-warped, chipped.

It shouldn't fly. But it breathes. Loyal. Fast. Held together
by will.

Kataria slams the ignition rune. The Strix GROANS. A shudder
through the deckplates.

CLO
These coordinates don't look real.

KATARIA
They're not supposed to.

VEERA (V.O.)
Trajectory is off-Seam. No
registered lane. No recovery
beacon. If the drive fails, we
drift until we don't.

KATARIA
Noted.

CLO
She's saying we die, Kat.

KATARIA
I heard her.

She doesn't look up from the controls. Her hands are steady.
Her jaw is not.

EXT. DOCKING SLIP - NIGHT

Engines spool. Plasma coils hum.

BLASTER FIRE rains from above.

Two LEDGER AGENTS drop from a vent shaft. More flood from the
shadows.

LEDGER AGENT
Breach of collections protocol.

BLAM. Kataria fires from the cockpit window. One agent spins
back.

CLO
I thought we had three days!

KATARIA (O.S.)
Corporate math, Clo!

INT. BOARDING CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Clo sprints. Opens portside access. Blaster bolts scorch the
deck.

He hurls a FLASH CHARGE.

BOOM. White light and smoke swallow the bay.

Clo dives back up the ramp as stun-nets whirl past.

INT. COCKPIT

VEERA (V.O.)
Deploying sonic stun.

A PIERCING SHRIEK vibrates through the hull. Outside, agents clutch helmets, disoriented.

KATARIA
Push start protocols.

EXT. DOCKING SLIP - CONTINUOUS

Thrusters KICK. Debris whirls. Agents scatter.

A magnetic anchor fires. SLAMS into the hull. Then another. The Strix GROANS, dragging against two tethers. A third anchor launches. Locks.

The ship lurches. Engines scream against dead weight.

INT. CARGO BAY - SAME TIME

Clo rips one tether free. The second holds. The third is buried in the hull plating.

VEERA (V.O.)
Three mag-locks. Two accessible.
One fused to the cargo bay outer wall.

CLO
Meaning?

VEERA (V.O.)
Meaning the anchor goes, or the cargo goes. Not both.

Clo looks at the bay. Salvage parts. The stealth core from the drone. Reactor components. Three months of scrounging bolted to the deck. Everything they need to keep the Strix flying.

CLO
(into comm)
Kat. They've got us pinned. I can blow the cargo clamps and we're free. Or I cut the anchor manual, but it's a sixty-second job and they're already on the ramp.

INT. COCKPIT - SAME TIME

Kataria's eyes move across the console. Fuel. Shields. Engine temp. All redlining.

Outside, a FOURTH ANCHOR launches. Misses. Sparks off the hull.

KATARIA
Blow it. All of it.

CLO (O.S.)
Kat, that's three months of.

KATARIA
Dead people don't need inventory,
Clo. Blow it.

INT. CARGO BAY

CLAMPS FIRE. Bolts detonate in sequence. The deck splits open.

Salvage, parts, the stealth core, reactor components, all of it DROPS through the bay doors. Tumbling into the docking slip below. Agents dive clear as two tons of metal rain down.

The last anchor RIPS FREE with the falling weight.

The Strix LURCHES upward. Clean. Fast. Empty.

The shard in Kataria's jacket flares once. Warm against her ribs.

EXT. DOCKING SLIP - CONTINUOUS

The Strix BLASTS into the upper lanes. Behind it, agents pick through scattered salvage on the bay floor.

INT. COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Clo drops into co-pilot. Quiet. His hands find the console.

CLO
We just threw away our repair
margin. Next thing that breaks,
stays broken.

KATARIA
Then nothing breaks.

Her hands blur over controls. Ships whip past outside.

CLO
Veil lock in progress.

VEERA (V.O.)
Trackers inbound. Ledger and
Syndicate.

KATARIA
Blind them.

VEERA (V.O.)
Decoys away.

A FLARE BLAST rocks the ship. Panels spark.

CLO
This is a bad plan!

KATARIA
Not a plan. A lifestyle.

She dives the ship into a narrow grav-gap.

EXT. SKYWAY - NIGHT

The Strix skims under haulers. Vanishes between lanes.

INT. COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

The Veil vector aligns. Stars stretch.

CLO
Veil drive ready.

VEERA (V.O.)
Trajectory: unstable. Off-Seam in
three. Two. One.

Kataria's hand hovers over the ignition rune. One breath.

She SLAMS it.

EXT. THE STRIX - VEILSPACE

The ship LURCHES. Jagged stormlight TEARS open, swallowing
them.

Alarms scream. Hull rattles. The viewplate fractures into
prismatic shards of impossible light.

Then: SILENCE.

The Strix drifts in the Veil. Storm-light ripples across the hull. The passage holds. They're through.

INT. COCKPIT - VEILSPACE

Kataria exhales. Hands still on the controls. Knuckles white.

Clo leans back. Neither of them speaks for a long beat.

The console CHIRPS.

A corrupted signal. Riding the Veil current like flotsam. Veera intercepts it.

VEERA (V.O.)
Anomalous transmission. Piggybacked
on our Veil wake. Decrypting.

The display scrambles. Fragments of code. Static. Then it resolves.

A SHIP REGISTRATION. Axiom Corp corvette. Classified designation.

And a name on the pilot authority line.

DRAETH VORN. STATUS: ACTIVE.

Kataria stares. Her breath stops.

Clo sees it too.

CLO
That's not possible.

She doesn't answer. Her fingers grip the edge of the console. The shard in her jacket PULSES. Hard. Urgent.

Pulling toward the coordinates ahead. Toward Echorift.

But the signal came from BEHIND them. From something following.

VEERA (V.O.)
The signal originates from a vessel
in geosync above Meridian Station.
It entered Veil-shadow
approximately seven minutes after
our departure.

CLO

He's alive. And he's following us.

Kataria's jaw works. No words come.

The console holds two vectors. The Echorift coordinates, burning steady ahead. And the signal trace, pulsing behind. Two directions. Two kinds of answer.

She stares at both. The shard pulls one way. Her hands want the other.

The shard's hum rises. Warm against her skin. The warmest it has ever been.

She looks at the Echorift vector. Looks at the signal trace. Her hand moves to the console.

She keys the Echorift heading. Locks it.

Her eyes stay on the signal trace until it fades from the display.

SMASH TO BLACK.

The shard's hum fills the darkness. Low. Constant. Waiting.